

Shaoxuanzi Sheng

shengsxzi@gmail.com | +86 15057817860 | Durham, NC / Beijing, China

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Chinese politics; authoritarian governance; state building and state capacity; central–local relations; policy experimentation; political communication; comparative politics; media and politics in East Asia.

EDUCATION

- **Duke University** August 2025 – Present
M.A. in Political Science; GPA: to be updated
◦ Advisor: Melanie Manion.
◦ Master's thesis in progress: *State Presence as State Building*.
Durham, NC, USA
- **Communication University of China** September 2021 – June 2025
B.A. in Political Science and Administration, State Governance and Political Communication; GPA: 3.87/4.00
◦ Selected coursework: Politics; Data Analysis and Application; Statistics; Social Science Research Methods; Economic Mathematics; Introduction to Political Communication; International Communication.
Beijing, China
- **University of Notre Dame** August 2023 – December 2023
Exchange Program, Department of Political Science; GPA: 3.75/4.00
◦ Selected coursework: World Politics: Introduction to Comparative Politics; Media & Politics in East Asia; Digital Empires; Korean Society and Politics.
South Bend, IN, USA
- **Peking University–The University of Chicago International Policy Action Lab** July 2023 – August 2023
Summer School
◦ Coursework: Applied Econometrics; Programming in Stata; Public Policy Capstone Project.
Beijing, China

WORKS IN PROGRESS

- [W.1] **“Beyond Payoff Maximization: Authoritarian Resilience and Policy Experimentation in China.”** Work in progress.
Develops a risk-management account of policy experimentation in authoritarian regimes. The project argues that regional resilience—capturing structural, institutional, and social capacities—shapes pilot selection and post-reform outcomes, especially in high-risk reform domains where the central government must balance performance payoffs against the containment of policy failure and social externalities.
- [W.2] **“Crisis-Driven Institution Building: Evidence from COVID-19.”** Working paper, with Xiongfeng Xiao.
Develops a sequential theory of crisis-driven institution building in which crisis pressure first generates emergency institutions and these institutions subsequently sediment into routinized governance. The empirical analysis uses a country-week panel of COVID-19 responses from 2020 to 2022, fixed effects, and a leave-one-out exposure instrumental-variable design based on pre-pandemic mobility networks.
- [W.3] **“Administrative Reform as Institutional Purge: Evidence from Vietnam.”** Working paper, with Xiongfeng Xiao and Qingwen Deng.
Develops a theory of institutional purge in authoritarian administrative reform. Using Vietnam's 2025 province-level consolidation, the project combines a formal model with an original dataset linking province-level institutional survival, central elite profiles, and local elite career networks to show how rulers may preserve or destroy institutional platforms through which political resources are distributed and reproduced.
- [W.4] ***State Presence as State Building*.** Master's thesis in progress, Duke University.
Examines how state presence contributes to state building in contemporary China. Current writing stage; project description to be expanded after the thesis design and empirical strategy are finalized.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- [C.1] Sheng, Shaoxuanzi. 2024. “Where Is Our Future”: Political Attitudes Under the Impact of Narrative Expression in Science Fiction Films—A Comparative Study Based on Utopian Chinese and Dystopian American Films.
Accepted by the 53rd Annual Meeting of the SouthWest Conference on Asian Studies (SWCAS).

HONORS AND AWARDS

- **Bronze Medal Project** 2024
“Challenge Cup” Beijing Research and Entrepreneurship Competition Beijing, China
- **Special Award for Research Reports** 2023
School of Government and Public Affairs, Communication University of China Beijing, China

ACADEMIC SERVICE AND LEADERSHIP

- **Student Group Leader**
Editor Team, Studies of Chinese Political Communication
May 2023 – September 2024
Beijing, China
- **Founder and President**
CUC Model Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference Club
August 2022 – September 2023
Beijing, China
- **Member, Secretary Team and Promotion Team**
The Fifth China's Political Communication Studies Academic Forum
May 2023
Beijing, China
- **Youth Representative**
The 2023 Chinese Young Politician Forum
May 2023
Beijing, China
- **Student Leader**
CUC Institute of Political Communication Studies' MOOC Project: Political Communication
October 2021 – August 2022
Beijing, China
- **Officer, New Media Department**
Student Union, School of Government and Public Affairs, CUC
October 2021 – September 2023
Beijing, China
- **Event Operation Officer**
CUC Alumni Association
September 2021 – August 2022
Beijing, China

SKILLS

- **Software and Programming:** Python, Stata, SPSS, Microsoft Office Suite, Photoshop, Premiere, Final Cut Pro.
- **Research Methods:** Formal modeling, causal inference, instrumental variables, fixed effects, social network analysis, content analysis, survey research, experimental design, quantitative data analysis, qualitative research, literature review.
- **Languages:** Mandarin Chinese (native); English (proficient).